



THE “CANNON” VIOLIN

Made by luthier Giuseppe Guarneri, this powerful violin was one of a magnificent collection of instruments owned by Niccolò Paganini.

Success, wealth, and tragedy

That same year, 1828, aged 46, the composer set off on a European tour to Austria, Bohemia, Germany, France, and England. The shows were astonishing for the musician’s energy, technical wizardry, and lightning-fast passages (Berlioz referred to him as a “comet”)—by all accounts, he could play 12 notes a second and never followed sheet music. These sensational performances of his own works thrilled audiences, fueling speculation that he was in league with the devil (see [box](#)). But in 1834, ill health brought an end to his tours. He died in Nice six years later from throat cancer. His fortune was left to Achille.

Paganini revolutionized violin-playing and was particularly famous for radical techniques such as spiccato and left-hand pizzicato. Apart from his magnificent instrumental 24 Caprices, his other compositions